

IS IT ROMANCE OR IS IT FEAR?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery that is free of sexual promiscuity and addictive behavior.
2. Identify and correct thoughts that trigger sexual promiscuity and learn to practice self-talk that promotes healthy sexual behavior.
3. Identify connections between childhood relationships with alcoholic, addicted, or otherwise dysfunctional parents and dysfunctional love relationships in adult life.
4. Achieve insight into the roots of dysfunctional relationships with both alcoholic parents and adult partners in feelings of responsibility for others' behavior.
5. Identify healthy nonromantic relationships in adult life and create a model for healthier love relationships.
6. Identify early warning signs to avoid future dysfunctional relationships.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PROBLEMS WITH SEXUAL PROMISCUITY

- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Forming Stable Relationships
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Codependent Behaviors
- Using My Support Network
- What Does Addiction Mean to Me?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?
- Working through Shame

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Borderline Traits
- Partner Relational Conflict

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The "Is It Romance or Is It Fear?" activity is intended for clients who have a pattern of forming un-

healthy love relationships with dynamics echoing their childhood relationships with their alcoholic, addicted, or otherwise dysfunctional parents. This exercise would be appropriate at a point in treatment when the client is presenting with complaints of either dissatisfaction with a current dysfunctional relationship or loneliness and desire to establish a healthy relationship. Follow-up could include reading assignments or viewing films related to this topic (see the book *Rent Two Films and Let's Talk in the Morning* by John W. Hesley and Jan G. Hesley, also published by John Wiley & Sons).

IS IT ROMANCE OR IS IT FEAR?

Do you find yourself in romantic and/or sexual relationships with partners who are abusive, dishonest, neglectful, or otherwise bad for you; relationships that always seem to end in heartbreaking humiliation, fear, or abandonment? Do you find that even though you believe you would be happier in a relationship with someone who was honest, considerate, and dependable, that people who are like that seem boring while the “bad boys” or “bad girls” excite you? This exercise will help you examine and understand that excitement, so that you can start changing this painful pattern in your life.

1. First, please take a few minutes to reflect on the relationship or relationships that stand out in your mind as having been hardest to get over. Use this space to write the first name or names of the partner(s) you were with.

2. Now, for each person you named, think about what happened that was most hurtful. The kinds of experiences that are most painful include verbal and emotional abuse, physical abuse, sexual abuse, dishonesty, emotional instability, undependability, abandonment, infidelity, neglect, emotional unavailability, and alcoholism, addiction, or other irresponsible and self-destructive behavior by our partners. In the following space, for each person you named, please list the things that happened that caused you the most unhappiness, especially if they were repeated patterns of behavior.

3. If you listed more than one relationship, do you see any common trends or patterns? For example, some people find that they get into relationships with partners who are unfaithful and involve them in romantic triangles, over and over. Others may find that they are repeatedly drawn to alcoholics, workaholics, batterers, or sex addicts. If you see any patterns like this, please describe them here.

4. Now, we'd like you to shift gears and think about your relationship with your alcoholic, addict-

ed, or otherwise dysfunctional parent or parents. In most families where a parent has these problems, the children are emotionally neglected, and the other parent at times feels part of a love triangle, because the alcoholic or addicted parent's real primary relationship is with the drug of choice. So even in the absence of other human romantic or sexual involvement, there are often the same feelings that occur when a parent/partner is having affairs. Impaired parents are also more likely than others to be verbally, emotionally, and/or physically abusive, neglect their families, be dishonest, abandon their families, be neglectful, undependable, emotionally unavailable, and to be irresponsible, emotionally unstable, and self-destructive. Look at the patterns you listed for your most painful love relationships, and circle any that also describe your childhood relationship with your parents. What common patterns do you see?

5. When those things happened in your childhood family, which of the following emotions did you feel: fear, anger, anxiety, shame, or despair? What about other painful feelings?
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6. When those things happened in your love relationships, which of those emotions did you feel?
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7. It is a normal pattern in childhood to feel responsible for whatever other people do that affects us. This is why children often blame themselves for their parents' divorces, depressions, rages, drinking, and other problems. Even if the child doesn't consciously think, "It's my fault that they did that," he/she will often have the feeling that "if only I were a better kid, if only I could say or do the right thing, they'd act differently." If you felt that way as a child, please use this space to name some things your parents did that you felt you should have changed somehow.
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8. Now, moving back to adolescent and adult love relationships, do you remember having that same "if only . . ." feeling that if you'd just done something differently, things would have been better? If you do, name some experiences where you've felt that way.
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9. If you are like most adult children of alcoholics, you will see that the dysfunctional partners to whom you have been attracted have had much in common with your parents, and that you've experienced many of the same patterns and feelings in those relationships. You may have already realized this, or this may be a new awareness. Either way, if you are seeing this kind of similarity, use this space to describe the emotions this brings up for you, and your thoughts about what you could do about it.

10. One of the most attractive qualities of dysfunctional partners is often their intensity, and the excitement and intensity we feel when we're with them. Is this true for you? _____
11. Another relationship that is characterized by similar intensity and excitement is the relationship an addict has with his or her drug of choice, especially if the drug is a stimulant like cocaine or methamphetamine. Do you see other parallels between an addict's relationship with a drug and your painful relationships with both your parents and past partners?

12. Take a moment to imagine your ideal partner. Please circle the six qualities from the following list that would best describe the person you'd like to be in a relationship with.

Honest	Humorous	Kind	Healthy	Patient	Intelligent
Positive	Courageous	Spiritual	Loyal	Practical	A good parent
Practical	Emotionally strong	Dependable	Playful	Sensitive	Unselfish

13. Now think about your closest nonsexual, nonromantic relationship today. This could be with a best friend or a family member. Which of the qualities you circled describe that person?

14. Is that person exciting to be around in the way that your partner in your most painful relationship may have been? _____ If not, which relationship has been more emotionally rewarding and better for you? _____
15. Again, if you are like most adult children of alcoholics, you will find that you have at least one relationship with a person who has the qualities you'd most like to have in a partner. If you see this is true for you, this is good. It shows you that such people do exist and that you are capable of forming a quality relationship of some kind with one of them. Now write some of your thoughts about what it would be like to be in a loving relationship with a person whose personality was similar to the person you thought about for question 13.

16. Knowing that such a relationship would probably lack the intensity and excitement of an addic-

tive relationship, would you rather be in this type of relationship or in another addictive love? How could you change your behavior to seek out this type of partner and relationship rather than getting into other addictive relationships in the future?

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.